Gas

By José Rivera

CHEO stands next to a pump at a gas station, about to fill his car with gas. He is a working-class Latino.

CHEO: **(Pg 35-42)** His letters were coming once a week. I could feel his fear. It was in his handwriting. He sat in a tank. In the middle of the Saudi Arabian desert. Wrote six, seven, eight hours a day. These brilliant letters of fear. This big Puerto Rican guy! What the hell's he doing out there? What sense does that make? He's out there, in the Saudi sand, writing letters to me about how he's gonna die from an Iraqi missile. And he's got all this time on his hands to think about his own death. And there's nothing to do 'cause of these restrictions on him. No women, no magazines, 'cause the Saudis are afraid of the revolutionary effects of ads for women's lingerie on the population! Allah would have a cow!

INTRODUCTION

It is 2003 . . . the United States has launched a major military invasion of Iraq -- the start of an 8-year conflict that resulted in the deaths of more than 4,000 U.S. servicemembers and hundreds of thousands of Iraqis. Millions of Americans protest the invasion, carrying signs and banners that read "No Blood for Oil."

What role did oil play in the decision to invade Iraq? We may never know for sure. Saddam Hussein was, after all, a brutal dictator who with weapons of mass destruction and ties to terrorist groups. No, oil did not ***make*** *the U.S. war against Iraq inevitable – but it was an especially attractive added incentive.*

"No Blood for Oil" -- For weeks and weeks, Cheo has received letters from his brother, a soldier stationed in the Saudi Arabian desert. Then one day the letters stop, and Cheo is left unsure if his brother is alive. He begins to question the cost of soldiers as collateral damage and the phrase "No Blood for Oil."

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CHEO: There's nothing he's allowed to eat even remotely reminds him of home. Nothing but the time to sit and think about what it's gonna be like to have someone run a bayonet clean

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through his guts. He's sitting in the tank playing target practice with the camels. Shooting at the wind. The sand in all the food. Sand in his dreaming. He and his buddies got a camel one day. They shaved it clean! Completely shaved it! Then they spray-painted the name of their company, in bright American spray-paint, on the side of the camel, and sent it on its way!

Scorpion fights in the tents! All those scenes from *Apocalypse Now* in his head. Marlon Brando decapitating that guy and Martin Sheen going nuts. That's what fills my brother's daily dreams as he sits out there in the desert contemplating his own death.

The Vietnam Syndrome those people are trying to eradicate. His early letters were all about that. A chronicle. His way of laying it all down, saying it all for me, so I would know what his last days and months, and seconds were like. So, when he got offed by an Iraqi missile, I would at least know what it was like to be in his soul, if just for a little while.

He couldn't write to save his life at first. Spelled everything totally, unbelievably wrong. "Enough": e-n-u-f. But with time, he started to write beautifully. This angel started to come out of the desert. This singing angel of words. Thoughts I honestly never knew he had. Confessions. Ideas. We started to make plans. We started to be in sync for the first time since I stopped telling him I loved him.

I used to kick his a**! It wasn't hard or nothing. That's not bragging, just me telling you a simple truth. He was always sick. Always the first to cry. He played drums in a parade back home. He couldn't even play the stupid instrument, he was so uncoordinated. Spastic. But they let him march in the parade anyway -- without drumsticks. He was the last guy in the parade, out of step, banging make-believe drumsticks -- playing air drum for thousands of confused spectators! Then he got into uniforms and the scouts. But I knew that was just its cover anyway. He didn't mean it. Though after he joined the army and was in boot camp, he took particular delight in coming home and demonstrating the fifty neat new ways he learned to kill a guy. One day he forgot he weighed twice my weight and nearly snapped my spine like a cucumber! I thought, in agony, "Where's my bro? Where's that guy I used to kick around?

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The first one to cry when he saw something beautiful. The first one to say 'I love that' or 'I love Mom' or 'I love you.''' He never got embarrassed by that, even after I got too old to deal with my little brother kissing me in front of other people. Even later, he always, always, always ended every conversation with, "I love you, bro." And I couldn't say, "I love you" back, 'cause I was too hip to do that.

But he got deeper in it. The war thing. He wrote to say I'd never understand. He's fighting for my right to say whatever I want. To disagree. And I just love how they tell you on the news the temperature in Riyadh, Saudi Arabia! Like I care! And a couple of times he called me collect from Saudi! I said ***collect***! And I told him if Saddam Hussein didn't kill him, I would!

He told me about troubles with his wife back home. He'd just gotten married a month before shipping out. He didn't really know her and was wondering if she still loved him. My brother always loved ugly women. It was a thing with him. Low self-esteem or something. Like he couldn't love himself and didn't understand a woman that would. So, he sought out the absolute losers of the planet. Love! He didn't know another way. Then he met a girl who on their first date confessed she hated spics -- so my brother married her! This racist looked him in the eye, disrespected his whole race to his face, and my brother says, "I do."

Last night somebody got on TV to say we shouldn't come down on rich people ‘cause rich people are a minority too, and coming down on them was a form of racism! And I thought, they're afraid of class warfare, and they should be! And the news showed some little white punk putting up flags all over this town in California and this little twerp's story absorbed twenty minutes of the news -- this little, blond Nazi kid with a smile full of teeth -- and the protests got nothing**.**

And this billboard went up in my town showing Stalin, Hitler, and Hussein, saying we stopped him twice before we have to stop him again! This billboard was put up by a local newspaper! The music, the computer graphics, the generals coming out of retirement to

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become media stars. And we gotta fight NAKED AGGRESSION -- like this president should come to my neighborhood if he wants to see naked aggression!

I never thought the ideas in the head of some politician would mean the death of my brother and absolutely kill my mother. I'm telling you, that woman will not survive the death of my brother no matter how much she believes in God, no matter how much praying she does. But I keep that from him. I write back about how it's not going to be another Vietnam. It's not going to be a whole country that spits on you when you come back. That we don't forget the ones we love and fight for us.

Then his letters stopped. I combed the newspapers trying to figure out what's going on over there, 'cause his letters said nothing about where he was. He wasn't allowed to talk about locations, or troop size, or movement, 'cause, like, I was going to personally transmit this information to the Iraqi Ministry of Defense! I thought about technology the new Iraq has that was made in the United States, that could penetrate a tank's armor and literally travel through the guts of a tank, immolating every living human soul inside, turning human Puerto Rican flesh into hot screaming soup, the molecules of my brother's soul mixing with the metal molecules of the iron coffin he loved so much. I couldn't sleep. My mother was suicidal. Why wasn't he writing?

The air war's continuing. They're bombing the hell out of that country! And I find myself ashamed. I think, "Yeah, bomb it more. Level it. Send it back to the Stone Age. Make it so every last elite Republican Guard is dead. So my brother won't get killed." For the first time in my life, I want a lot of people I don't hate to die 'cause I know one of them could kill the man I love most in this messed up world.

And I'm sick. I'm sick of rooting for the bombs. Sick of loving every day the air war continues. Sick of every air strike, every sortie. And being happy another Iraqi tank got taken out and melted, another Iraqi bunker was bombed, another bridge can't bring ammunition, can't deliver that one magic bullet that will incapacitate my brother, bring him back a vegetable, bring him back dead in his soul, or blinded, or butchered in some Iraqi

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concentration camp. That the Iraqi that would torture him won't live now 'cause our smart bombs have killed him in his sleep! They actually got me wanting this war to be bloody! *(beat)*

Last night the ground war started. It started. The tanks are rolling. I find my gut empty now. I don't have thoughts. I don't have dreams. My mother is a shell. She has deserted herself and left behind a blathering cadaver, this pathetic creature with rosary beads in her hands looking up to Christ, and CNN, saying words like "Scud," "strategic interests,"" collateral damage," "target rich environment" -- words this woman from a little town in Puerto Rico has no right to know. So, I fight my demons. I think of the cause. Blood for oil. I NEED MY CAR, DON'T I? I NEED MY CAR TO GET TO WORK SO I CAN PAY THE RENT AND NOT END UP A HOMELESS PERSON! DON'T I HAVE A RIGHT TO MY CAR AND MY GAS? AND WHAT ABOUT FREEING DEMOCRATIC KUWAIT?! *(beat)*

So, I wait for a sign, anything, a prayer, any sign, I'll take it. Just tell me he's okay. Tell me my brother's gonna kill well and make it through this alive. He's gonna come home and he's gonna come home the same person he left: the spastic one who couldn't spell. . . the one who couldn't play the drums.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: José Rivera
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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier – MS NIETOC
MN State Qualifier
ND State Qualifier

NOTE: More about the US/ Iraq war can be found here

https://www.pewresearch.org/politics/2023/03/14/a-look-back-at-how-fear-and-false-beliefs-bolstered-u-s-public-support-for-war-in-iraq/

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